

How to Write a Synthesis

A great synthesis walks readers through a series of ideas and sources to prove or explain a larger point. Follow this step-by-step guide for writing your essay.

1. Do your research.

Once you've decided on a topic, use the internet, library, and other sources to perform extensive research. You can turn to academic primary sources to find quotes from scholars and experts or look up statistics or scientific studies relevant to your topic. This research will help you develop a point of view that is backed up by concrete information. Use credible sources that are unbiased and objective.

2. Outline your point.

Your entire synthesis should focus on either explaining a certain perspective or making an argument. Outline how each of your sources relate to your theme and support your idea.

3. Write your introduction.

An introduction is the first paragraph of a paper. Its main purpose is to present the general premise of the paper, provide any necessary background information, and hopefully, capture the reader's attention. The introductory paragraph to your synthesis should be where you include a strong thesis statement. This is where you will state the point of view that you're exploring or the argument you're making.

4. Include your body paragraphs.

A synthesis will typically contain as many body paragraphs as the number of distinct sources you aim to discuss. A good body paragraph contains three main sections: a topic sentence (or key sentence), relevant supporting sentences, and a closing (or transition) sentence. This structure keeps your paragraph focused on the main idea, providing clear, concise information. Each body paragraph should discuss different elements and supporting arguments of your thesis, along with evidence drawn from each source. Explain the common theme between your resources, as well as how they are relevant to your text. Include counter arguments as well as how your source material can discredit those claims and support your own idea.

5. Wrap it up with a strong conclusion.

A conclusion is the final piece of writing in a research paper, essay, or article that summarizes the entire work. The concluding paragraph of your synthesis will restate your thesis, summarize the key supporting ideas you discussed throughout the work, and offer your final impression of the central idea.

6. Proofread.

Always proofread your writing a few times before submitting or presenting it. A few missed words or grammatical errors can sometimes change or discredit the entire crux of an

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argument or opinion. Make sure that your grammar, syntax, and flow are as accurate and clear as possible. This will help you come across as a credible source.